Tuticorin merchants. Even though all these creditors were prominent shareholders, they were unwilling to initiate liquidation. Ponnuranga Mudaliar attributed this to 'fear of public displeasure' and the fact that nothing more could be lost apart from suffering ignominy.[22] This was a specious insinuation. If shareholders cum creditors did not want liquidation, the only logical conclusion would be that they valued the company over money. Surely, avoiding humiliation was a laudable desire.

Meanwhile, it was also said that B.K. Ramaier held a mortgage on the *Lawoe*.[23] Such reports notwithstanding, there was a flicker of hope: in early April the *Lawoe* was sailing on the coast and calling at Kakinada.[24] Having left Colombo, and touching Thirumullaivasal, it was carrying 2,000 bags of rice on its return to Colombo.[25] On 15 April, the *Lawoe* called again at Kakinada returning from Colombo, carrying over 200 bags of areca nut. When it left for Madras less than a week later, on the evening of 27 April, it was loaded with 1,400 bags of oil-cakes and bones, etc.[26] Again, a fortnight later, it arrived from Kakinada at Madras harbour laden with oil-cakes and rice bags.[27] On 30 April, calling at Madras on a voyage between Kakinada and Colombo, it was loaded with 527 bags of rice.[28] This was a healthy schedule for a steamer laid up for long. The police contended that the voyages could not have been viable; an assessment difficult to verify.[29]

Reports of P.V. Ganapathia Pillai travelling between Tuticorin and Colombo in late April and early May could mean that there were continuing efforts to keep the company going.[30]

But by this time, even Bharati had given up hope. In one of the last issues of his daily *Vijaya*, before it closed down following its proscription under the Indian Press Act, 1910, he wrote:

> If this company should fail, there cannot be a greater disgrace than this for the people of Southern India. We will be looked down upon by the Englishmen and other foreigners. They already have no respect for Indians, and in the case of Southern Indians, it is still worse. The Britishers consider the people of Bombay as friends, those of Bengal as tigers, and those of Madras as slaves. If our chief Swadeshi enterprise should also fail, we need not state to what further extent we will go down in their estimation?[31]